ARKANSAS

The Natural State



Long before Arkansas was a state, the rivers knew the people by their nets. The Mississippi, the Arkansas, the White—these waterways were larder and highway both, and the channel catfish that lurked in their muddy bends fed families from the Ozark highlands to the flat Delta cotton fields. For the Quapaw people, who called the confluence of the Arkansas and Mississippi home for generations, catfish was a staple taken year-round, salted, dried, or roasted over river-cane fires.

When French and later Anglo-American settlers pushed into the Arkansas Territory in the early 1800s, they brought with them cast-iron skillets, lard rendered from hog fat, and a taste for cornmeal. In the kitchens of Little Rock, Pine Bluff, and the river-landing towns like Helena—perched on a bluff above the Mississippi—those two traditions met. Enslaved Black cooks, who held the deepest culinary knowledge in the plantation South, perfected the technique that endures today: a dredge of coarse yellow cornmeal seasoned with salt, black pepper, and cayenne, then a plunge into shimmering, near-smoking lard or oil. The result was a shattering golden crust encasing sweet, flaky white flesh.

By the late 19th century, Friday fish fries had become a cornerstone of Arkansas social life, cutting across race and class in a region where little else did. Along the Helena waterfront—once one of the busiest ports on the lower Mississippi—commercial fishermen like the Tatum family sold catfish straight from their boats in the early morning. By noon, the smell of cornmeal frying in iron pots drifted from every church yard, juke joint, and roadside stand. In the Delta flatlands around Lake Village and Dumas, catfish farming would eventually take root in the 1960s, turning the state into one of the nation's top producers and turning a tradition that had been informal into an agricultural industry as well.

The tartar sauce that accompanied those fish, however, was Arkansas's own spin—stubborn and particular, like the people who made it. Where Louisiana might reach for hot sauce and Creole mustard, and Tennessee might keep it plain, Arkansas cooks reached into the pickle crock. Sweet pickle relish—often made from the summer cucumber harvest, put up in Ball jars by the dozens—stirred into good mayonnaise with a sharp squeeze of lemon and a whisper of hot sauce became the region's signature condiment. Some cooks add a spoonful of yellow mustard; others a grated boiled egg. Every family claims their version is the correct one. They are all correct.

Today, fried catfish remains Arkansas's unofficial state dish—served at family reunions along the White River, at fish fries that double as church fundraisers in Dermott and McGehee, and at restaurants from West Memphis to Fort Smith. It is, above all, a food of belonging, shaped by the convergence of Native, African, and European hands over two hundred years beside the water.

FRIED CATFISH WITH ARKANSAS-STYLE TARTAR SAUCE

Pulled from the muddy bends of the Mississippi and the White, Arkansas catfish fries up crisp, golden, and unmistakably Southern.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4–6 catfish fillets
- 1 cup buttermilk
- 1 cup yellow cornmeal
- ½ cup cornstarch
- 1 tsp paprika
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- ½ tsp cayenne
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying
- Lemon wedges, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare fish*: Pat the fish dry, then soak it in the buttermilk for 15–30 minutes. This helps tenderize the fish and adds flavor.
2. *Mix breading*: In a large shallow dish, combine the cornmeal, cornstarch, and all the seasonings. Mix well.
3. *Heat oil*: Fill a large skillet or deep fryer with enough oil to cover the fillets. Heat the oil to 350°F (175°C). Use a thermometer to monitor temperature.
4. *Coat the fish*: Remove the fillets from the buttermilk and dredge each fillet in the cornmeal mixture, pressing lightly to coat evenly.
5. *Fry the fillets*: Carefully place the fillets into the hot oil, cooking 2–3 at a time to avoid overcrowding. Fry for 3–5 minutes on each side, or until golden-brown and fish flakes easily.
6. *Drain and serve*: Transfer fish to a plate lined with paper towels to drain excess oil. Serve immediately with lemon wedges.

ARKANSAS-STYLE TARTAR SAUCE

Yield: about ½ cup

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup mayonnaise
- 2 Tbsp sweet pickle relish (or finely chopped pickles)
- 1 tsp hot sauce (Crystal)
- 1 tsp lemon juice
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- ½ tsp onion powder
- ¼ tsp smoked paprika
- Salt and pepper, to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the tartar sauce*: In a bowl, mix all the ingredients until well combined. Adjust salt, pepper and lemon juice to taste. Chill for at least 15 minutes before serving.

